HCP 1511 - A mixed Pigpen letter from Felton

Origin and context

HC Portal record **1511**, catalogue name **pc_hcp_192**, is a postcard addressed to Edith Elsworth in Burlingame, California. Its picture is captioned “Part of Felton, California” and shows the Grand Central Hotel. The postmark preserves day **31** and year **1913**; the month cannot be securely read. The portal listed the date as Unknown. The author is unidentified.

The portal capture of 26 October 2026 showed Not solved. General, Description and Attachments were inspected; the two scans had no attached transcription or solution. No published plaintext was used in this attempt.

Source: https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1511

The message mixes ordinary cursive with thirteen Pigpen word fragments. There are **73 non-cancelled cipher positions** and one blackened correction. That count includes positions whose dot or outline is ambiguous at the available resolution. It is not a count of 73 independently certain glyphs.

Method and corrected key

The Pigpen signs alternate undotted and dotted letters. Most outlines are consistent with an interleaved alphabet, but the rightward wedge appears where the surrounding text requires both W and Y. The overwritten W-position in WOODEN cannot be securely distinguished from the clear Y-position wedges in LIVERY and LIBRARY. The original claim of one exact alphabet without exceptions was therefore withdrawn after review.

Outline	Undotted	Dotted
Bottom/right corner	A	B
Bottom/left/right	C	D
Bottom/left corner	E	F
Top/bottom/right	G	H
Four sides	I	J
Top/bottom/left	K	L
Top/right corner	M	N
Top/left/right	O	P
Top/left corner	Q	R
Downward wedge	S	T
Leftward wedge	U	V
Rightward wedge	W or Y in context	not established

X and Z do not occur in the recovered words; their signs are not established. No upward Y wedge is supplied merely to make the table unique.

The thirteen words

The contextual readings, in source order, are:

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HOUSE, LOUISE, PORCH, LONG, WOODEN, STORE, SALOON,
BARBER, SHOP, FRANKS, LIVERY, STA[cancelled]BLES, LIBRARY
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They fit the prose and the photograph. The scan-led alternatives remain:

Position	Scan-led alternatives	Contextual reading
PORCH final sign	H/J, open/closed frame	H

Human solver: Tomáš Pavuk

Position	Scan-led alternatives	Contextual reading
WOODEN first	G/W/Y, overwritten right frame/wedge	W
WOODEN second	O/P, dot uncertain	O
WOODEN fourth	C/D, dot uncertain	D
WOODEN sixth	M/N, dot uncertain	N
LIVERY final	W/Y, rightward wedge	Y
STABLES L	J/L, nearly closed frame	L
LIBRARY final	W/Y, rightward wedge	Y

G is possible at WOODEN's first position only if its outline is the alternative right-side frame. It is not a proposed alternative word. The cancelled mark inside STABLES remains unrecovered. The two plain cursive ampersands immediately after LOUISE and between SHOP and FRANKS are not Pigpen signs.

Running text

Uppercase words below are contextual readings of the encrypted fragments; the remaining text is a best manual reading of the cursive prose. It is not a diplomatic transcription of every stroke. Unread marginal continuation is explicitly marked.

Dearest Edith, Here it is. The little HOUSE here at the left is where LOUISE & I were last Sun. afternoon on the PORCH. The LONG building at the side of the house is the WOODEN STORE. The Hotel has the sign on it. The SALOON, BARBER SHOP & FRANKS store & the LIVERY STA[cancelled]BLES are on the right out of sight. The building with the x is where they have the LIBRARY. It is nothing now. Just full of old old magazines & papers. Last yr. they had books but they have all been taken. [Further closing/marginal cursive writing not securely read.]

Slovak translation: „Najdrahšia Edith, tu to je. V tom malom dome vľavo sme boli s Louise minulú nedeľu popoludní na verande. Dlhá budova vedľa domu je drevený obchod. Hotel má na sebe nápis. Hostinec, holičstvo, Franksov obchod a stajne s ustajnením či prenájmom koní sú napravo, mimo záberu. V budove s x majú knižnicu. Teraz to nie je nič, je len plná starých, starých časopisov a novín. Vlani mali knihy, ale všetky už odniesli. [Ďalší záver a text na okrajoch nie sú spoľahlivo prečítané.]“

FRANKS is not identified with a particular owner or business. A visible x-like cross lies on the roof of the building to the right of the Grand Central Hotel (approximately original picture x825,y307). A new working crop records it. This fits the prose marker; it does not independently verify the building's historical use as a library. The translation does not turn contextual references into independently verified facts.

Independent review and response

Review 1 by **Claude Opus 5.5**, dated 26 October 2026, returned REVISE. The reviewer independently read all thirteen fragments and confirmed the words, while refuting the original shape/key record. All five findings were addressed:

1. The two falsely transcribed upward Y wedges were changed to observed rightward wedges. WOODEN's overwritten first outline is recorded as an alternative. The key openly permits W/Y ambiguity; no unique key is claimed.
2. Uncertain WOODEN dots and PORCH/STABLES outlines are listed by position and represented as alternatives in the manual transcript and decoder.
3. Both plain ampersands adjacent to cipher fragments are now explicitly recorded, outside the cipher count.
4. The running prose and translation were added, with unread text marked.
5. The old claim that no date was established was corrected to 1913, with day 31 visible and month unread. The original portal capture was preserved.

These corrections change the evidence record rather than the thirteen word interpretations. The reviewer stated that another round was unnecessary once the record was corrected as described. The limits above remain material.

Reproduction and limits

From the repository root:

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python3 ciphers/hcp-1511/work/decode.py
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The command checks hashes of the unchanged originals, expands the uncertain manual outline/dot tokens, and prints observed alternatives beside contextual word readings. It checks that each selected letter belongs to the observed candidate set. It does not claim a unique inverse-key roundtrip, perform OCR, or automatically recover the cursive prose. Source and review files were unchanged. Successful decoding of hand-made tokens alone is not independent pixel evidence; the review and explicit shape alternatives supply that record.